



“Agriculture is and always will be the backbone of the Indian economy... To us, farmers are like Gods, and serving them is like worshipping God... I am fortunate to have been given this responsibility by the PM”

speeches]. After that, from 1951 to 1958, there was no mention of the word. The late Indira Gandhi, whom I respect very much, imposed levies on farmers, and their grain was forcibly collected by officers. She also said that higher prices could not be given. There was even a Prime Minister who, when told red chillies fetched higher prices, responded, “Then why don’t farmers grow red chillies instead of green ones?”

As for the current leaders, I won’t say much, but for them, farmers and agriculture are just part of vote bank politics. The Congress ruled for many years but did nothing significant [for farmers]. The Congress even stated in a Cabinet note that giving MSP at 50% of the cost would distort the market and could not be implemented... It’s easy to make promises during elections, but when they were in power, they did nothing.

Narendra Modi believes in doing solid work, and continuous efforts are being made in that direction for agriculture and farmers.

If the Congress talks about MSP for farmers, then look at how much the MSP was when the Congress was in power. Congress governments purchased only around 100,000 metric tonnes of pulses, while we purchased 17 million metric tonnes. This is an achievement of the Narendra Modi government. Look at the rates, the approach, the quantities—the Congress never did anything.

Agriculture is primarily a state subject. The central government sets the MSP and makes purchases, but many state governments do further work, and the Haryana government has made a good decision.

SZ: A frequent complaint of farmers is that the central government keeps imposing export restrictions. But governments also need to keep prices in check. Is it the right thing to do?

A: First, we must ensure that there is income for farmers and give them a remunerative price. But at the same time, we need to consider that during Covid-19 or because of the Russia-Ukraine war, we could export more wheat. We also need to ensure that our population has enough food. We have to provide grains through the public distribution system, so we must assess how much grain we have to feed our population. In such circumstances, it becomes our primary duty to give the farmer MSP, while ensuring that our people have sufficient food grains to eat.

RK: You had introduced the ‘Ladli Behna’ scheme before the Madhya Pradesh elections. Some people in the BJP thought this